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Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/59328004.

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Not Rated

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# starling, we’re the lucky ones - a catradora proposal

by calaflowers


Summary

“Will you stay with me forever?”

Adora feels conflicted about her relationship with Catra, but doesn’t know when the right time to move on would be. On the other hand, Catra’s plan is perfect—at least she thinks it is. When an opportunity presents itself to Adora, she gets down on one knee. But, so does…Catra?


Notes

hii!! i recently finished rewatching she-ra for the second time around, since i hadn’t seen any of the seasons since their release dates in 2018-19-20. oh boy i had forgotten how much of a she-ra fan i am let me tell you 🥵

i wanted to make sure i was writing catra and adora’s characters correctly, and i just couldn’t figure out which one of them would propose first, so that’ll make a nice surprise for you 😉
so, enjoy the outcome of my catradora obsession coming back once again, and please do not copy, repost, or alter in an way. thank u and enjoy!!

ooh also i literally listened to “starling” by sarah kinsley on repeat while writing this. it’s heavily inspired by it, so go give it a listen!!

Adora’s shoulders relaxed as Catra placed her hands on them, and she let out a heavy sigh of relief. There was nothing to stress over, she would have a good time with her friends at Scorpia and Perfuma’s ball that evening. But something about the sight of the married Glimmer and Bow exiting the room made her feel… anxious—she wanted that for herself soon. Of course, her girlfriend was heaven-sent. But it had been a good few years since the two had adapted that title for each other. She felt ready to move on; to take a leap with their relationship. The longing would leave her soon enough. She had the first step in her pocket, she just didn’t know when the right time would be.

“You coming?” the said girlfriend released Adora’s shoulders and walked around in front of her, holding out her hand.

Adora’s eyes glanced up from where she was staring at the ground and to Catra’s delicate hand that was encased in a deep maroon fingerless glove. Her smile was even more fragile and soft, with her top lip curling in and her small canines peeking out from the corners of her mouth. Adora smiled back, hiding her feelings. “Yeah. Yeah, I’m coming.” She took hold of Catra’s hand, a sudden rush of happiness washing over her. The small embrace was what she needed.

Catra took the lead out of the room, but instead turned down a different hallway than the one Glimmer and Bow had gone down. Adora’s mindset shifted from her deep longing for something more with Catra, to, “Wait, Catra, this is the wrong way.”

Catra let out that raspy, high-pitched giggle of hers, turning around and walking backward as she dragged Adora by both her

hands. “Are you sure, princess? I think I’ve come to memorize the knotty layout of this place over the years.”

“Mmh, yeah, your mental map of Bright Moon is messed up, ‘cause this is the way to the balcony,” Adora smirked, looking around at the flying shades of pink from the murals on the wall as they ran past them.

Catra scoffed, “Oh, shut up, I was teasing you. I know where we’re going—there’s something I want to show you!”

At her words, Adora turned her head to look into the golden and blue eyes staring back at her. She smiled and let out a genuine laugh as Catra chuckled and turned back around to lead the way through the glittering halls.

The white stone double doors parted, the sunlight stinging Adora’s eyes as she lifted her hand to prevent the bright star from blinding her. Her girlfriend bounced happily out to the edge, her grip still tight on Adora’s right hand. Catra swung Adora around by pulling back and spinning in a circle, coming to a stop with just mere inches between their lips. The birds of the Bright Moon grounds sung in rejoice at the sight of these fellow lovebirds. Catra stepped back a few inches and looked out over the luscious greenery, still holding onto Adora’s hands.

“What was it you wanted to show me?” The dirty blonde asked. At the sound of her voice, Catra turned back to look at Adora.

She smiled. “Adora. I–”

“Did somebody say, ‘Swift Wind!’”

Catra jumped back and yelped, her tail sticking straight out almost comically. She-Ra’s steed, Swift Wind flew up to the pair suddenly and let his hooves land on the ground. “What’s goin’ on, fair ladies?” He said loudly, unaware of the startle he gave his companion’s girlfriend.

“Swifty,” Adora patted his nose. “No one said ‘Swift Wind.’”

Swift Wind looked back and forth between Adora and the distressed Catra with a hopeful smile stretched across his face. He hung his head low when he got the memo.

“Adora, will you please tell your horse to leave,” Catra sighed.

Adora mouthed, “Sorry,” as she turned to Swift Wind, who whinnied in perception and turned to bother the guards who were enjoying apples in the shade.

“So!” Adora turned to Catra, who looked like she was going to be sick. “Hey … what’s the matter?” She gently put her hands on Catra’s shoulders.

“I just wanted to steal you away for a moment …” Catra limply fell into Adora’s arms, like this inconvenience—this interruption of her plan had drained all her energy. Adora caught the sad cat, her dumbfounded expression quickly fading into a saddened look, her eyelashes visible to her own eyes. They slumped down onto the marbled tile together, Catra’s head resting against Adora’s chest as her arm sat gently around Catra’s waist. There had been many times when they had sat in each other’s arms, curled up on the floor, but a melancholy moment like this always brought her the memory of hugging Catra for the first time in three years. At this moment, Adora realized Catra longed for the same thing she did. And as much as she wanted to stay there on the warm ground in the sunlight with this girl on her lap, she needed to put on a brave face for Catra—and for herself. “Hey.”

Catra looked up at her.

“What’s with the sudden mood swing? I know you don’t particularly enjoy Swifty’s extra attitude, but …” Adora brought her free hand up and stroked Catra’s ear with her thumb.

The cat leaned into the embrace and sighed. “I wanted to have you to myself for a bit before we headed out for the ball. And the flowers, the sunlight—it all felt perfect for the occasion because we live here together, now, Adora.”

Adora smiled at her sweetly. Catra looked into Adora’s eyes. My gosh, she loved that girl so much. She loved the smile she reserved for Catra and Catra only. The smile she gave her before they kissed for the first time; the smile she gave her when they both survived the nearest to death she hoped they would ever be;

the smile she gave her every night since then. “I think I’ve finally come to accept that,” Catra continued the previous sentence.

Adora let out a quiet laugh through her nose, leaning in closer to Catra. “I’m sure I would’ve loved whatever it was you had in store for me.”

Catra laid her head back down on Adora’s lap in defeat. “I’m sorry,” she whispered as she wrapped her tail around Adora’s leg.

“Nuh-uh,” Adora waved her index finger back and forth. “No apologies.” She shifted her legs so she could stand up, and picked her girlfriend up in her arms as she stood. “Now c’mon, I know where we can go for a little privacy.” Catra looked up at Adora, who looked straight ahead, determined to turn this day around. Her hair bellowed freely in the wind as she walked with a purpose, no longer reminded of her low point when the hair tie broke and Horde Prime stood before her, telling her there was no hope for Catra—that She-Ra’s power was the only thing mattered. He made her feel like a mere husk of a girl; just someone to carry around the spirit of the Princess of Power. Now, she knew she was more than that—she was Adora and She-Ra, with or without the sword. And as Adora, she would make sure Catra knew she mattered.

With all this in mind, she stopped under a tree and set Catra down in a garden chair that accompanied a small tea table and another chair of the same design. It was quiet, set aside from the rest of the palace grounds, perfect for what Adora imagined Catra had in mind.

And it was almost like she could read Adora's mind. "This is perfect, Adora," Catra said, as she breathed in deeply, feeling a wave of serenity come over her. Over the last few years, Perfuma and Adora had helped her see the beauty in the life around her and overcome the anguished thoughts of the past that used to come back to her at the sight of Adora's scars; the touch of her own neck where the chip had once been. Now, Adora embraced her scars—her ballgown even had an open back, revealing the pink claw marks that Catra left on her under Prime's control—and Catra allowed her to; kissing the ones on the left side of her face from time to time.

"Good," Adora responded, sitting in the open chair and scooting it over so she was closer to Catra. "We have a few minutes before we should get going. You wanna just stay here for a bit?"

Catra nodded, then looked up at the blooming flowers that the cherry tree was producing at that time of year. Adora did the same, and the two sat in silence. Though they weren't engaged in conversation, they shared the same thought process. And they both held a ring in their pocket.
"Hey, Adora," Catra sat up and cleared her throat.

"Yeah?"

"I've been thinking about the future a lot, actually," Catra looked down and kept her hand on her leg, feeling where the tiny, round piece of metal sat, safe and secure.

Adora's eyes widened, cutting Catra off. "Me too!"

Catra smiled, not giving her agreement a second thought. Instead, she continued. "I can't imagine a life without you. You and your idiotic hair poof; you and your instinct to carry everyone's problems on your shoulders no matter the burden; you and that smile you give me every time I call you 'princess'—Adora, look, you're doing it right now," Catra snorted, her hand motioning to Adora's dumb smile. She burst out laughing too.

"Catra," Adora sighed happily after calming down. "I never want to throw this away. We've known each other since we were so little, and that's not a love story you hear every day. When I see my future, I see you."

Catra's heart raced. This was it.

Adora looked at the girl she would spend the rest of her life with after this moment. The girl that she had already spent all her years leading up to this moment with.

They both reached into their pockets simultaneously, each pulling out a ring.

"Catra—"
"Adora—wait."

The two girls looked at each other in confusion and astonishment as the rings between their fingers gleamed in the sunlight.

"Were you going to …?" Adora drew out her question, unsure of how to finish it.

"Are you serious right now." Catra's expression stretched out and her brows lowered.

Then Adora began to laugh. "Did we really just do that?" She slumped back in her chair, rubbing her forehead, the ring squeezed tight in her fist.

"Okay, okay, okay," Catra started to chuckle and figure out how to move on. "You have a ring. I have a ring."

Adora sat back up and looked at Catra for a good thirty seconds. Then she gave a quick smirk. "Hey … were you about to propose to me?"

Catra stood up, pushed her hand against Adora's face, and plopped down in her lap. "Yes, dummy, I was proposing to you, because I'm such a sap," she said playfully.

"At least you had somewhat of a plan," Adora chuckled, leaning in. "I had no idea I was gonna pop the question this early."

“Really? The master of battle plans had no idea how she was gonna propose to her girlfriend? Wouldn’t have seen that one coming.”

“Oh, come on. Just show me the ring.”

As Catra held the golden ring in front of Adora’s eyes, it dawned upon her that this was, truly, actually happening. Adora was engaged to the girl she chose, and the girl chose her. She covered her mouth with her hands as she looked closer. “Catra …” A tear rolled down her cheek. “Is this …?”

“I had Entrapta melt one of the shattered pieces of your sword into the ring, yeah,” Catra said quietly through the smile that formed as she saw Adora’s reaction. “Do you like it?” Her tail swished back and forth as she perched atop Adora’s lap.

“I love this,” Adora looked into Catra’s eyes, which were closer than before. “So much. Put it on.”

Catra did so. Adora held out her right hand and she slipped the golden band on her ring finger. It fit perfectly, and Adora held it up against the sun, admiring the new object symbolizing their love for each other. “Okay,” Adora sighed, turning back to Catra and holding up the ring she had for her. It was a simple silver band, but a small red gem carved into the shape of a peony was the main focus of the ring in its entirety. The transparency of the gem immediately caught Catra’s attention. “Wow, I … It’s beautiful,

Adora.” She held out her hand quickly as Adora slipped it over her claw and down her ring finger. “Thank you,” Catra smiled softly, pressing her forehead to Adora’s. She purred quietly as she felt their skin touch.

“Y’know, neither of us has said yes, yet,” Adora said, not pulling away just yet. “Scratch that.” She pulled away, her smile fading as she realized: “We haven’t even asked each other the actual question.”

Catra laughed through pursed lips. “Okay, idiot!” She stepped down off her perch and bent down on one knee, her burgundy red shirt perfectly complimenting the dark green of the grass. “Sparkles taught me how to do this part.”

“Glimmer knew about this?” Adora asked surprisingly, almost laughing at herself for not knowing.

“Sh-sh,” Catra shushed her and cleared her throat. “Adora Happysmile Rainbowfist?” she looked up happily into the bluebell eyes that stared down at her, shrinking in width as Adora smiled at the reminder of the full name Catra had given her when they were cadets. “Will you stay with me forever?”

Adora nodded vigorously, tears now staining her cheeks as she smiled that dumb smile. “Yeah. Yes, I’ll stay.”

She crouched down off her chair and slowly wrapped her arms around Catra's shoulders. "Catra Applesauce Elizabeth Meow Meow," she whispered into Catra's ear, making her laugh quietly. Adora pulled away, looking back and forth between the golden and blue eyes that she adored. "Will you marry me?"

"Only an idiot would say 'no,'" Catra remarked, smiling.

"Good thing I've never called you an idiot then," Adora said playfully, tightening her grip on Catra's shoulders.

Catra laughed slightly; happily. "I'm gonna marry you."

Adora let out a heavy sigh, but not in an unsatisfied way—she had just been holding her breath in awaiting a response. The two looked into each other's eyes as Catra pressed her lips to Adora's. Letting go, smiles grew on their faces. And as uneven and emotional as they were, they were beautiful. Imperfect. Scarred, healed, broken in so many ways and fixed by the love they shared for each other. The rings each caught a glint of sunlight as the two girls reached for one another's faces, their lips interlocking once more.

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